



2026 AI CREATIVE IMPACT REPORT

The future of creative work depends on how effectively leaders and talent unify their approach to AI.

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About This Report

We're in a new chapter for creative work, and it's critical that teams and leaders get on the same page.

When it comes to AI, what we're hearing from both leaders and talent is consistent: there's momentum and curiosity mixed with genuine unease, and it's all happening at the same time.

And even though AI is currently active in most daily workflows, the strategy and structure around it are lagging. The opportunity now is to bring both into sync.

Using data from real conversations and surveys from leaders and creatives, this report offers grounded, practical insights to help leaders better align direction with day-to-day creative work.

This report isn't a tool review or playbook. It's a look at where teams are today, where alignment is breaking down, and what it will take to better connect leaders and talent.

Our Methods

| How We Explored AI in Practice.

Our approach blends quantitative survey data with qualitative insights from live discussions to understand how AI is truly showing up in creative and marketing work today.

We used AI throughout the research process to analyze patterns, pressure-test assumptions, surface unexpected angles, and challenge our own bias, while our copy and design team helped shape the final narrative.

Representing both sides of the work experience was essential. We intentionally elevated the voices of both leaders and talent to better understand barriers, confidence, usage, and sentiment around AI's impact on creative work.

At the close of 2025, we conducted two surveys:

- Leaders (n=78) including creative and marketing leaders from brands such as Mastercard, JetBlue, Lenovo, DraftKings, Carta, The Trade Desk, Kenvue, and GoPro.
- Talent (n=75) across disciplines including design, copy, project management, videography, and marketing.

To add depth to the data, we also hosted five moderated focus groups—two with leaders and three with talent. Tools such as Gemini Notes and NotebookLM supported documentation and synthesis, allowing us to stay fully present in conversation while capturing detailed insights.

Along the way, we experienced many of the same friction, wins, and “ah-ha” moments participants described. Ultimately, the narrative was shaped through human interpretation and contextual understanding. We’re grateful to our team and to everyone who shared their experiences.

The Current Outlook

Creative teams are moving faster than ever, but not always in the same direction.

While experimentation is widespread, shared standards, confidence, and clarity are still catching up. The result isn't resistance or failure, but a growing gap between how AI is used day-to-day and how it's guided at the leadership level.

To better understand this moment, we've broken the current outlook into three connected themes:

1. Adoption without alignment

2. Confidence with hesitation

3. Concern mixed with excitement

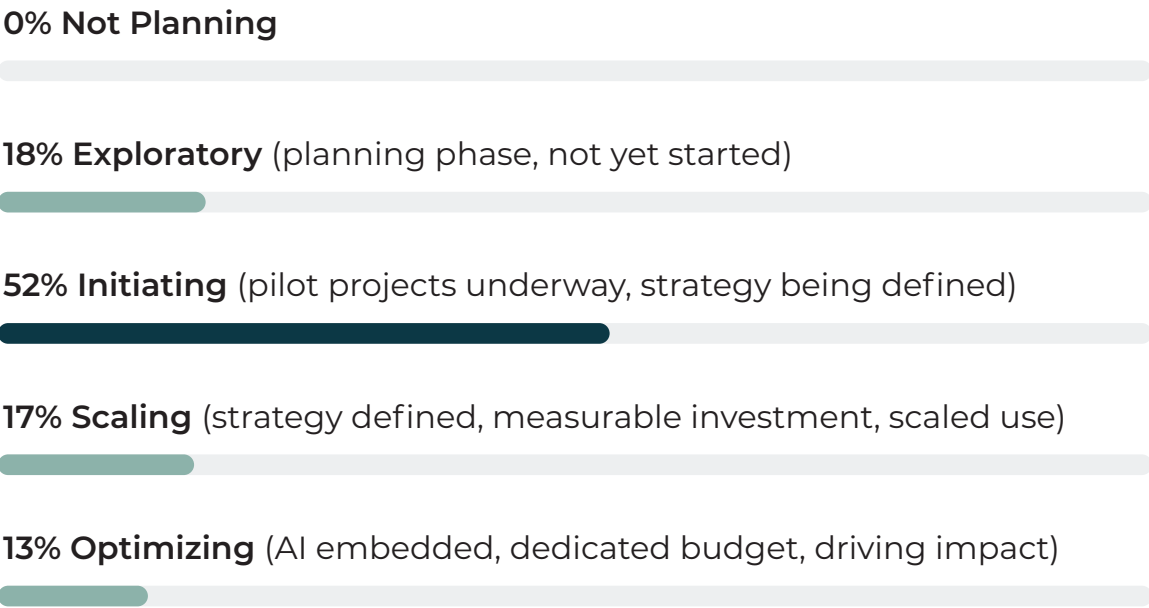
Together, these paint a picture of how teams are moving presently, as they seek more structure, alignment, and team success.

Adoption is outpacing structure.

Many leaders are stuck in the early stages of adoption, without proper structure and clarity. Meanwhile, talent is experimenting with AI before formal guardrails or standards are in place. This has created the perfect environment for “shadow AI” to thrive.

“Shadow AI” refers to the informal, unsanctioned use of AI tools by individuals or teams.

Leader’s Self-Reported AI Adoption Stage



Source: Leader survey, Q7, n=78

Leaders and talent feel hopeful about AI’s impact on their work despite the uncertainty that exists in their day-to-day lives.

Talent

68% of Talent rate AI’s impact on their work as positive

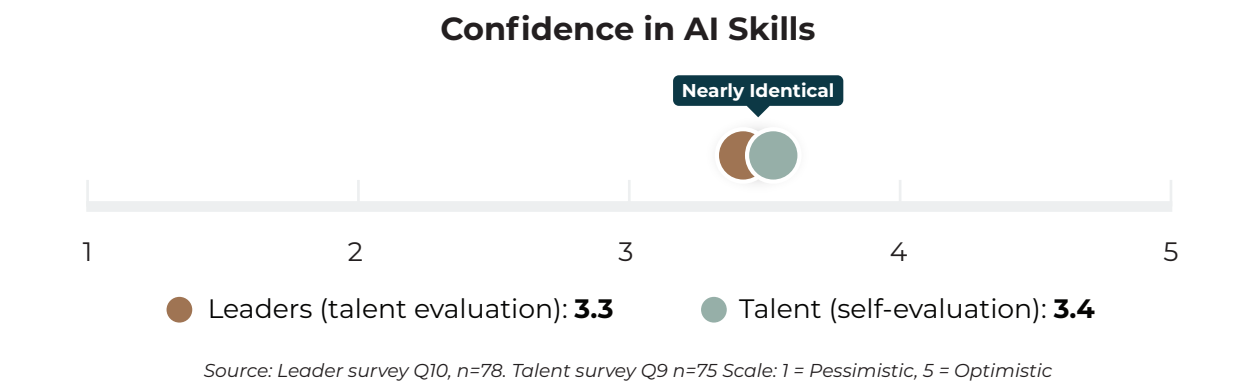
Leaders

77% of Leaders rate their team’s attitude towards AI as optimistic.

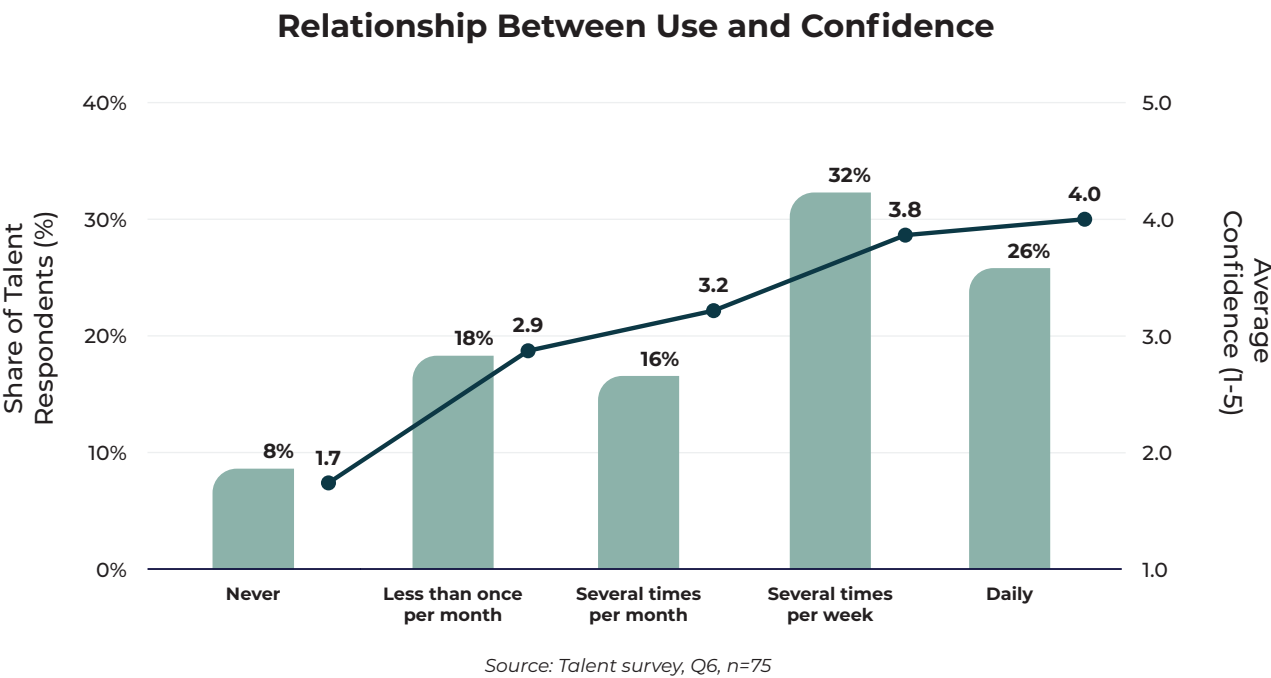
Both leaders and talent are asking for structure: clearer standards, smarter rollout, and practical support that turns optimism into progress.

Confidence is rising, but teams need more guidance.

When asked about their confidence in using AI tools, leaders and teams are mostly on the same page. But there’s still a gap between AI’s potential and our current capabilities. So how do we help solve this?



Talent who use AI regularly gain confidence at a rapid rate, but those who rarely touch AI still feel uncertain and stuck. The implication for leaders is clear: confidence follows use. This makes access, permission, and practice as important as training plans. But how much is enough? There’s no set recipe, but using AI at least once a week appears to be the critical threshold for developing the most confidence.



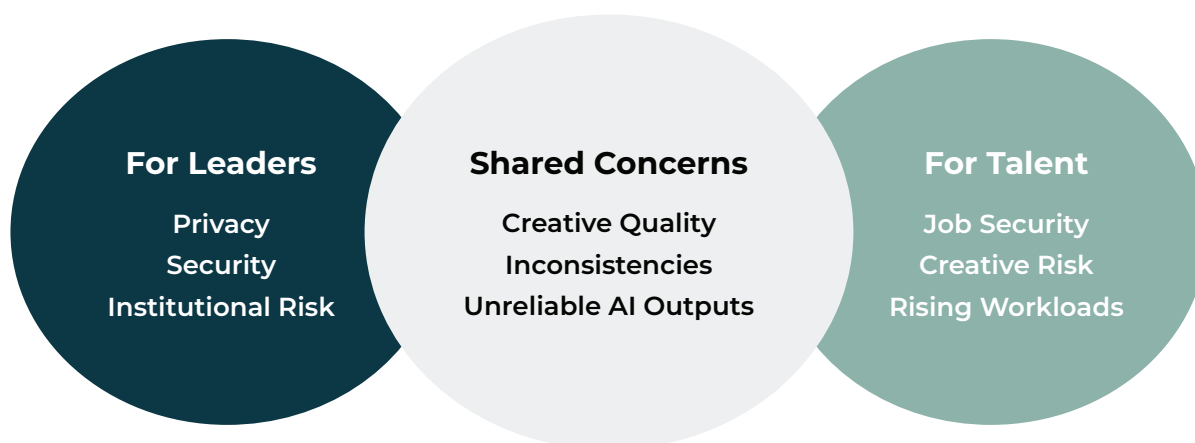
Optimism is high, but confidence is still building and it grows with access, permission, training, and regular use.

Growing concerns and the need for better clarity.

Creative talent and leadership agree that some of the biggest concerns about AI revolve around AI dulling human creativity. Speed gains are real, but both leaders and talent share a concern that efficiency, without intention, could undercut originality or creative depth.

Teams want AI to amplify their craft, not replace it. And the best teams are creating frameworks that protect creativity, IP, and long-term value for both the business and the people doing the work.

Biggest AI Concerns



Source: Leader survey, Q19, n=78. Talent survey Q15 n=75

Leadership is more likely to prioritize privacy and security (~36%) than talent. Conversely, talent is more likely to fear job loss (~57%) than leadership (~17%). Put simply: leaders are focused on protecting the organization, while talent is focused on protecting their careers and creative value.

68%

of talent view AI as a threat to creative quality and uniqueness.

38%

of talent say they're feeling more pressure to produce more in less time as leaders lean into AI most in scale-oriented work.

Source: Talent survey Q11 n=75

The takeaway isn't that these concerns are in conflict. It's that they're pointing to the same need for clearer standards and shared expectations.

Bridging the Gap

Turning alignment and understanding into maximum positive impact.

Enthusiasm around AI is high and it's being used more than ever, yet many leaders are unsure how to unlock meaningful value. What's getting in the way?

According to our survey, it's all about alignment, as leaders and talent often want the same outcome, but approach AI from different angles. Bridging this gap requires naming those differences clearly, aligning on intent and turning shared goals into cohesive, everyday workflows. And with this readiness, many teams are finding themselves thriving and succeeding.

1. Clarify success

2. Define the strategy

3. Understand training needs

The biggest barrier with AI's isn't belief. It's alignment between the people setting the direction and the people doing the work.

When there's alignment on how success is measured, everyone wins.

Leaders tend to prioritize AI as a way to drive efficiency and streamline workflows. Creative talent, on the other hand, are primarily using AI as a creative partner for ideating, concepting, and storytelling.

Top AI Skill Priorities for Leaders

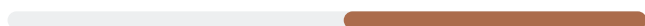
62% Efficiency

Workflow speed and task automation.



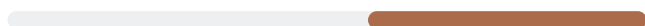
47% Innovation

New approaches and problem-solving.



44% Production

High-volume content generation.



Top AI Applications According to Talent

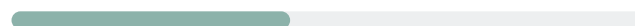
67% Concepting

Early-stage ideation.



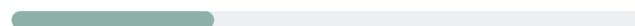
44% Copywriting

Content creation.



32% Research

Audience Insights.



Source: Leader survey Q13, n=78, multi-select

Measuring Success

Productivity metrics (speed + output)

- Cycle time
- Volume
- Rework



Quality metrics (craft + impact)

- Originality
- Brand fit
- Performance



With shared communication, defined strategy, and clear handoffs, teams can move faster and work more efficiently without sacrificing quality.

Creating a defined AI strategy eases pressure and helps remove roadblocks.

We’ve seen pressure for many organizations to adopt AI quickly, but speed without direction creates friction and slows adoption.

Almost half of organizations reported that their Executive/C-suite is primarily responsible for defining their AI strategy, followed closely by departmental ownership, then ownership by IT/tech functions. Traditionally, new technology has lived within IT, but we’re seeing a significant shift.

Our focus group discussions further reinforced that strong AI strategy requires representation from key functions like Marketing, HR, Legal, and IT. This cross-functional model allows teams to set guardrails together (like approved tools, privacy rules, and risk management), then translate them into real workflows and daily habits.

Top 5 Obstacles Slowing AI Adoption for Creatives and Marketers

Leaders			Talent		
1	Lack of training / Skill Gaps	44%	1	Uncertainty about legal / IP risks	44%
2	Budget constraints for new tools/upgrades	39%	2	Cost of tool subscriptions	40%
3	Data / Privacy risks and governance roadblocks	32%	3	Lack of training	29%
4	Uncertainty about ROI / Lack of clear business cases	26%	4	Lack of clear use cases	29%
5	Cultural resistance / Fear of change	17%	5	Time required for learning / Experimentation	28%

Source: Leader survey Q16, n=78. Talent Survey Q14 n=75, multi-select

When it comes to AI strategy, keep the model grounded by meeting regularly with cross-functional teams to review what’s working, update guidance, and remove blockers based on real day-to-day use.

Proper training empowers teams and leads to better results.

Once your strategy and guardrails are in place, adoption becomes an enablement challenge. Training is the lever that turns AI from experimental into a shared, repeatable way of working especially when it's grounded in real workflows, constraints, and standards.

*"Instead of telling them **not to**, tell them **how to**."*

— Shawni Danner,
Sr. Project Manager at Devpost

Where are teams finding the most success with training and upskilling?

Our findings suggest teams need role-specific training (not generic upskilling), clarity on what's safe and allowed, use cases that make value obvious, and time to experiment.

The most successful teams treat AI like a workflow redesign, not an add-on. As one leader put it: "Do not just bolt AI on... keep your human components at the beginning and the end of the process, so you don't lose your voice." That's the heart of effective training: protecting craft while increasing speed.

But getting training right starts with being specific about what you're actually teaching. Leaders in our focus groups stressed that "AI training" is not one thing. For some teams it's role-based use cases, for others it's policies and guardrails, and for power users it's prompting and output quality.

Tip: Identify your AI champions, your early adopters and experimenters, and turn their wins into mini case studies that the rest of the team can use.

When training reflects real work, AI stops feeling risky and starts feeling useful and exciting for all parties involved.

Turning Toward the Future

The future belongs to intentional creative teams.

As we lean into the future of creative work, the most effective creative teams won't be the fastest or flashiest. They'll be the most *intentional*.

AI will soon feel less disruptive and more normal and expected. Our hope is that won't be just because it's everywhere, but because it's been intentionally integrated. Instead of a shortcut, AI will be a support system that handles the heavy lifting so teams can focus on what only humans can do:

Be creative, explore wild ideas, and take risks

Fight for quality and taste

Develop and nurture the brand story

Mentor and inspire the next generation

The goal isn't automation for its own sake. It's better work, done more sustainably, by healthier teams.

Navigating the intersection of speed and quality.

The good news is that nearly half of talent feels encouraged to experiment. However, we're also seeing a similar percentage feel the pressure to produce more with less time. And this tension is holding teams back from reaching their full potential.

Expectations of Talent



42%
Feel more encouraged
to experiment



38%
Feel more pressure
to produce more
with less time

Source: Talent survey Q11 n=75

What can you do as a leader? Create structure and intention for your team(s) that also supports quality, rather than focusing solely on output and speed.

- Shared definitions of success
- Clear standards for when AI is appropriate and useful and when it isn't
- Defined use cases tied to real work
- Review checkpoints that protect craft without slowing momentum
- Shared learnings from experimentation, not isolated wins

"You've got to be very purposeful about creating the cultural shift... allowing them time to learn away from their daily tasks otherwise it'll not be embraced."

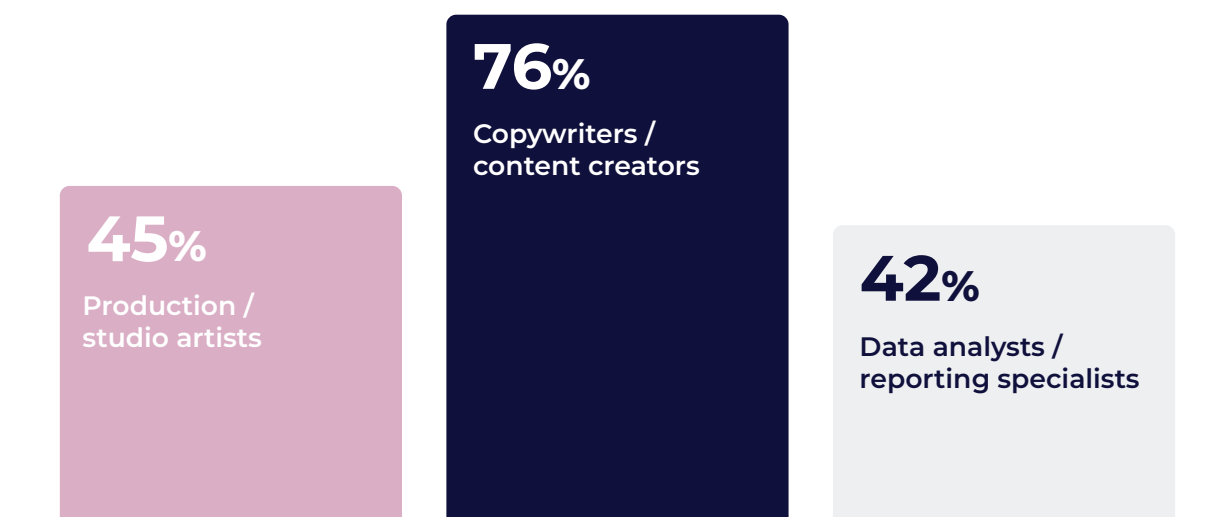
— Chris Perrins,
VP Brand and Creative at Carta

The teams that unlock the right balance will work faster and more effectively because they're moving with intention, standards, and clarity.

The role re-evolution: as speed accelerates, human input becomes more valuable.

Over the next few years, leaders expect AI to most impact first-draft, repeatable work (like copy and content roles), followed by production artists and reporting specialists. But as we learned through our conversations, it's not a straight replacement story. It's a value shift toward human direction and judgment.

Leaders Predict Most Impacted Roles



Source: Leader survey Q20, n=78

As drafting and execution become faster, the work that matters most becomes clearer. The most valuable contributors will be those who can:

- Frame strong prompts and briefs
- Apply judgment, context, and taste
- Edit, refine, and elevate AI-assisted work
- Make calls when there's no clear answer

“Taste and strategy will always need a human touch.”

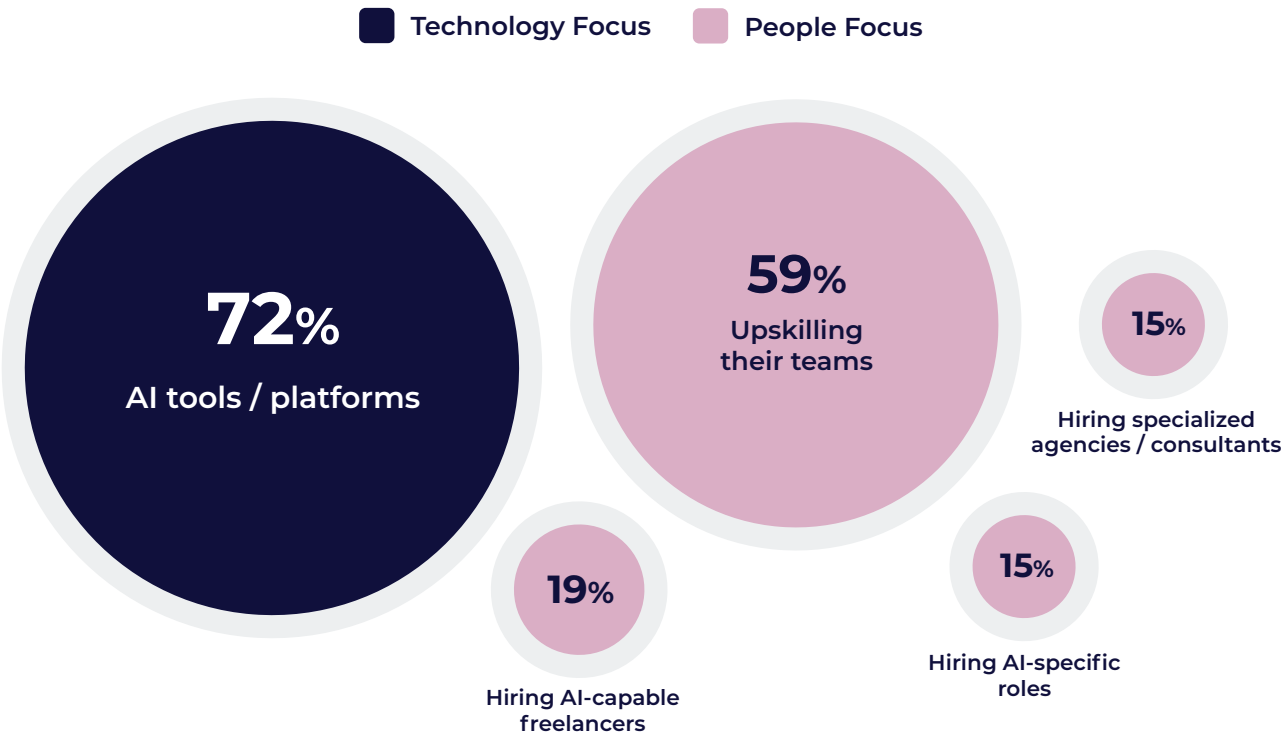
— Katelyn Kennedy,
Director of Creative Operations at ServiceNow

With AI handling more of the basics, developing early-career talent requires greater intention like mentorship and structured learning. If we want strong creative leaders tomorrow, we have to design for learning today.

Where leaders are investing.

Over the next year, leaders are making two parallel investments. Internally, they’re funding tools and upskilling to help teams work more effectively with AI. Externally, they’re tapping freelancers, specialists, and partners who already operate fluently in this new landscape. But the real differentiator is enablement, not just the simple act of procurement.

The tools matter, but support and training from leadership makes all the difference. Winning teams lead AI cross-functionally, set shared playbooks and guardrails, and train around real everyday use cases.



Leader survey Q15, n=78, multi-select

“Start with the use cases. Then decide whether the gap is solved through training, a new hire, or bringing in the right partner to accelerate capability.”

— Mark Cibort,
Global Marketing Operations Lead at Kenvue

Having the right tools is important, but the strongest leaders are building confidence, generating trust, and creating alignment as AI is introduced. That’s where lasting advantage is found.

The Winning Formula

So where do we go from here?

The next chapter of creative work is less about tools and more about intention. When leaders and talent align on goals, establish clear standards, and build trust across the organization, AI becomes a source of momentum, not tension. The result is more space for better ideas, healthier teams, and lasting creative impact.

Build a Strategy

Lead AI cross-functionally with shared ownership, standards, and guardrails.

+

Enable Your Teams

Equip teams with the right tools, clear expectations, and role-based training grounded in real work.

+

Lead with Intention and Clarity

Create safe space to experiment, then turn wins into shared, repeatable practice across the organization.

=

Future-Ready Teams

Winning teams will pair expertise with support to build cultures that adapt, innovate, and produce meaningful creative work as technology evolves. Technology alone isn't the advantage; it's the people powered by it.

Let's build your future-ready team together.
Contact us at info@worksandy.com